

Research Degrees Regulations

Twenty-Fifth Edition

August 2025



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SECTION 1. INTRODUCTION

Research Degrees Regulations – Twenty Fifth Edition (August 2025)

- 1.1 Revisions to Anglia Ruskin University (ARU)'s Research Degree Regulations, incorporated into this Twenty-Fifth Edition, were approved by the Senate on the 11th June 2025 for implementation from 1st August 2025. These regulations apply to all PGR candidates (new and existing) registered at all locations (including delivery by Academic Partners in the UK and overseas) for all research degree courses leading to an ARU award except for Higher Doctorates and PhD by Published Works which are published separately.
- 1.2 The Research Degrees Regulations are an on-line only document and can be accessed either externally via www.aru.ac.uk/researchregs, via [My.ARU](#) (for students) or [The Heron](#) (for staff).

Summary of Revisions to the Twenty-Fifth Edition

- 1.3 The minor adjustments reference changes that support the operation of these Regulations. Additionally, these Regulations signpost readers to ARU's comprehensive source of information which sets out policies and procedures on subject matter relating to incidents **of** harassment **and** sexual misconduct in response to the implementation of the Office for Students E6 requirements.
- 1.4 The revisions were achieved through consultation with our Community including the Research Degrees Regulations Working Group including representation from the Students' Union, the Directors of the Professional Doctorate, the Director of the Doctor of Medicine (Research), the Faculty Research Administrators Group, the Doctoral School Administration Team, the Secretary & Clerk's Office and the Research Ethics and Integrity Manager.

SECTION 2. PRINCIPLES

Foreword

- 2.1 All postgraduate research (PGR) candidates, University and Academic Partner staff are expected to adhere to these Research Degree Regulations. They are the principal means through which consistency in the academic standards across postgraduate research degree awards is ensured.
- 2.2 These regulations are subject to review. They embody practice as recommended in policies, codes of practice and regulations of the Office for Students (OfS), the Quality Assurance Agency (QAA), Universities UK (UUK), UK Council for Graduate Education (UKGCE), UK funding bodies, and research funding councils.

Relevant University Committees

- 2.3 The Research & Innovation Committee (RIC) exercises corporate responsibility, on behalf of the Senate, for the formulation of policy and strategy in relation to research and scholarship, and innovation and knowledge exchange.
- 2.4 The Senate's Research Degrees Committee (RDC) is responsible, on behalf of the Research & Innovation Committee, for the development of postgraduate research degrees in ARU and for developing, monitoring and reviewing ARU's quality assurance and enhancement policies and procedures for monitoring and reviewing the quality of the candidate experience.
- 2.5 The implementation and development of these regulations, and their associated processes, are overseen by the RDC.
- 2.6 The Postgraduate Research Candidate Progress Subcommittee (PGRCPSC) monitors and considered recommendations relating to the progress of PGR candidates at key stages in their award.
- 2.7 The RDC receives an annual report from each Faculty commenting on its PGR candidate activity including, inter alia, commentary on recruitment, retention, and completion rates and times. The Faculty reports will inform an annual institutional report which will also be tabled at the RDC.

Awards

- 2.8 ARU confers the following research degree awards: Master of Philosophy (MPhil), Doctor of Philosophy (PhD), Doctor of Philosophy by Published Works (PhDPub), Doctor of Medicine by Research (MD (Res)), Professional Doctorate (DProf), Doctor of Education (EdD), Doctor of Business Administration (DBA); Professional Master's (MProf); Master of Philosophy by Published Works (MPhilPub), Postgraduate Diploma in Professional Research (PGDipProf) and Postgraduate Certificate in Professional Research (PGCertProf) to registered PGR candidates who successfully complete the requirements for these awards.
- 2.9 Programmes of scholarly research may be proposed which can lead to presentation for examination in areas where ARU has academic expertise. These shall be considered on their academic merits and without reference to the concerns or interests of any associated funding body.
- 2.10 Master's level qualifications shall be awarded to PGR candidates who have:
- a critically investigated and evaluated an approved topic
 - b demonstrated an understanding of theory, research methods and development of applied skills appropriate to the chosen field and, in the case of the MProf, integration with Professional Practice,
 - c presented and defended a thesis by oral examination to the satisfaction of the examiners.
- 2.11 Doctoral level qualifications shall be awarded to PGR candidates who have:
- a critically investigated and evaluated an approved topic resulting in an independent and original contribution to knowledge and, in the case of Professional Doctorates and Doctor of Medicine by Research, professional and clinical practice respectively;
 - b demonstrated an understanding of theory, research methods and development and application of skills sets appropriate to the chosen field and, in the case of Professional Doctorates and Doctor of Medicine by Research, how they integrate with professional and clinical practice respectively;
 - c presented and defended a thesis by oral examination to the satisfaction of the examiners.

Collaboration with Other Bodies

- 2.12 The University encourages co-operation with external bodies e.g. industrial, governmental, commercial, professional or research organisations for the purpose of supporting PGR researchers in pursuit of postgraduate research degree awards. Formal collaboration may involve specialist input to the project and will be governed by contractual arrangements between the University and the external collaborator. The latter may also contribute financially and provide access to facilities, data or materials through a financial or in-kind arrangement. Where collaborative agreements in place, candidates and their supervisory teams must be attentive to the requirements of the collaborative agreements in place.

SECTION 3. ADMISSION AND REGISTRATION

General Entry Requirements for Postgraduate Research Courses

- 3.1 An applicant may seek admission to study for any of the following awards:
- a Master of Philosophy (MPhil)
 - b Doctor of Philosophy with progression from Master of Philosophy (PhD)
 - c Doctor of Philosophy (direct) (PhD)
 - d Doctor of Medicine by Research (MD (Res))
 - e Professional Doctorates (DProf), including Doctor of Business Administration (DBA) and Doctor of Education (EdD)
 - f Doctor of Philosophy by Published Works (PhDPub) - published separately
 - g Higher Doctorates (Doctor of Letters, Doctor of Science, Doctor of Technology, Doctor of Laws – published separately
- 3.2 ARU seeks to ensure that all applicants are considered on an equitable basis and that no applicants are considered less favourably due to their nationality, race or ethnicity, gender, marital status, disability, sexuality, political or religious beliefs or other unjustifiable grounds.
- 3.3 Entry is permitted only in the months of September, January and April except where it is a requirement of an external funder or research funding body.
- 3.4 An applicant seeking admission to a research award shall normally hold a first or upper second-class honours degree, in an appropriate cognate area, from an institution of higher education in the UK or a qualification which is regarded as equivalent. Admission to the award of PhD Direct is normally only permitted to an applicant who holds a Master's degree. Applicants seeking admission to a Professional Masters or Professional Doctorate award must also have appropriate professional experience and have access to relevant employment or practice.

- 3.5 An applicant for the MD (Res) must be in clinical practice and their proposal is expected to make a substantial contribution to knowledge in that area. They must have a relevant registerable qualification in Medicine awarded by a UK University or an equivalent qualification from outside the UK and hold full or limited registration with the General Medical Council (GMC). At ARU's discretion an applicant without GMC registration may be admitted providing that their research does not involve contact with patients.
- 3.6 Applicants holding other qualifications shall be considered on their merits and in relation to the nature and scope of the programme of proposed work. In considering an applicant in this category, the University shall look for evidence of the applicant's ability and knowledge in relation to the proposed research. Professional experience, publications, written reports, or other appropriate evidence of accomplishment shall be taken into consideration.

Specific Learning Support Requirements

- 3.7 Applicants and candidates with a disability or specific learning support need are strongly encouraged to disclose the nature of their disability and/or learning support needs to enable ARU to provide appropriate support during application and their studies. Those disclosing are referred to ARU's Student Support Services for the assessment of their individual needs. In making such a disclosure, ARU abides by all current legislation governing this area and makes reasonable adjustments to facilitate application and study at ARU. Any needs identified are considered confidential and shared only with appropriate Faculty and Professional Service staff within ARU.

Fraudulent Applications

- 3.8 ARU may withdraw an offer made where it is proven, or the university has a reasonable belief, that the application contained fraudulent information or where key information has been omitted.
- 3.9 Any registered PGR candidate suspected, following investigations, to have been admitted based on fraudulent information, or omitting key information, may be subject to our student disciplinary procedures as found in the Rules, Regulations and Procedures for Students.

English Language Competence

- 3.10 Where English is not an applicant's first language, they must hold ARU's English Language Proficiency Test (ELPT) or IELTS or a UKVI approved Secure English Language Test (SELT). The minimum required ELPT / IELTS score must be 6.5 and have achieved a minimum of English language competence of at least IELTS 5.5 (or equivalent) across all four disciplines – writing, reading, speaking and listening depending on the demands of the subject as determined by Faculty Directors of Research Students.
- 3.11 Applicants with a non-UK degree, delivered and assessed in the medium of English, may be accepted without the requirement to take an IELTS or equivalent test.
- 3.12 In all instances ARU reserves the right to require an English language test and/or attendance at a pre-sessional English language course as a condition of admission.

PGR Candidates Conducting Research Abroad

- 3.13 A faculty may approve an admission request from a candidate proposing to conduct research outside the UK, provided that:
- a provision is in place to provide regular supervisory contact through video conference.
 - b there is satisfactory evidence that the candidate has access to the facilities and resources required to support the research
 - c The candidate adheres to all appropriate procedures including ethical approval, a health and safety audit, insurance arrangements and UK and country specific legal requirements and permissions and governance checks for conducting their research (this is not an exhaustive list).

Previous Registration at Anglia Ruskin University

- 3.14 Where an applicant has previously registered as a candidate for a postgraduate research degree at ARU but failed to gain an award, the Faculty must be satisfied that the issues leading to the withdrawal or discontinuation have been addressed. Faculties may take account of all or part of the previous registration time in their offer of a place. This would only be appropriate where the proposed new research is similar to their previous registration.

- 3.15 Applicants who have been awarded the Postgraduate Diploma or Certificate in Professional Research may seek admission, within a period of five years of gaining that award, for entry onto the Professional Master's or Professional Doctorate in a related topic.

Applicants Transferring Registration from another Institution to Anglia Ruskin University

- 3.16 Where an applicant has commenced their research as a registered candidate for a postgraduate research degree at another institution a shorter than usual registration period may be approved which takes account of all or part of the time already spent on their research.
- 3.17 Where an applicant enrolled for a research degree elsewhere applies to transfer their enrolment and project registration to the University, the Faculty must be assured that the applicant's current institution (1) approves the transfer, (2) confirms the applicant's enrolment dates, (3) provides ethical approval and confirmation of any other approvals e.g. governance and regulatory checks required for the research is provided and (4) confirm that the applicant's progress during their studies has been satisfactory.

Concurrent Study

- 3.18 The Faculty Director of PGR Candidates may permit a candidate to register for a taught course concurrent with their postgraduate research degree registration, provided that at least one of the courses is studied part-time and the dual registration will not detract from the research.

Submitting Work for More Than One Award

- 3.19 A candidate will not be permitted to submit substantially the same piece of work for assessment for more than one award, either at ARU or elsewhere.

Transferring Course within Anglia Ruskin University

- 3.20 A PGR candidate who wishes to transfer their registration from one postgraduate research course to another must seek the written support of their First Supervisor or Professional Doctorate Programme Director before applying to the Faculty Director of PGR Candidates for approval. A candidate registered for the MD (Res) will not be permitted to change their registration to another postgraduate research degree. Visa holders must also ensure Compliance requirements are met prior to changing course.

The Selection Process

- 3.21 Selection of appropriately qualified and/or experienced applicants for admission to a postgraduate research degree is a Faculty responsibility. Applicants must be interviewed by an appropriately constituted Panel before a formal offer of a place is made.

Registration as a PGR Candidate of Anglia Ruskin University

- 3.22 All applicants who have accepted the offer of a place are required to register as a candidate of ARU and re-register for each year of their studies and pay due fees. Failure to do so will curtail access to ARU's facilities, support and continuation of studies.

Registration Period and Timescale for Completion

- 3.23 A candidate's programme of work should be designed so that their thesis is submitted by the expected thesis submission date. Candidates on funded Scholarships or collaborative awards should be attentive to expected submission requirements as stipulated in the Terms and Conditions for their funding or awards.
- 3.24 The minimum and maximum periods of registration are calculated from the initial date of registration.

Award	Mode of Study	Minimum	Expected thesis submission / Maximum period of registration (months)		
			Post Sept 2021 starters	Starting between Sept 2019 and 31st August 2021	Pre Sept 2019 starters
MPhil	Full-time	12	24 / 36	24 / 36	24 / 36
	Part-time	24	36 / 48	36 / 48	36 / 48
PhD via MPhil, including MPhil registration	Full-time	30	42 / 48	42 / 48	42 / 60
	Part-time	42	60 / 72	60 / 72	60 / 72
PhD (direct)	Full-time	24	36 / 48	42 / 48	42 / 60
	Part-time	36	60 / 72	60 / 72	60 / 72

MD (Res)	Full-time	24	24 / 48	24 / 48	24 / 48
	Part-time	36	36 / 72	36 / 72	36 / 72
Professional Doctorates	Part-time	36	54 / 72	60 / 72	60 / 72
Professional Master's	Part-time	30	36 / 48	42/48	42 / 48

- 3.25 Candidates commencing their studies before September 2021 must have submitted their thesis before the maximum registration date. Candidates commencing their studies from September 2021 must have undertaken their viva voce examination and received confirmation of their award before the maximum registration date. Candidates who do not meet these requirements may be discontinued.
- 3.26 Candidates ready to submit their thesis before the end of the minimum registration period may apply to the PGRCPSC to shorten their registration.

Changes to Registration

- 3.27 The PGRCPSC has oversight of applications to change to a candidate's registration, which should be made through the online PGR Progression monitoring system PGRPro, including changes to:
- a Research project or title
 - b Mode of study (full-time / part-time)
 - c Intermission*
 - d Extension to Registration
 - e Change of award e.g. PhD to MPhil
 - f *Professional Doctorate students intermitting in the taught stage of their programme should refer to the relevant section of the [Academic Regulations](#).
- 3.28 A PGR candidate holding a studentship (internal or external) must check the terms and conditions of the award permit such a change before they request a change of registration.

- 3.29 Candidates who are sponsored by the University under the Tier 4/Student visa immigration system must comply with their visa and immigration obligations, as set out on the Visa Compliance webpages or the International Student Advice webpages. It is the responsibility of candidates to ensure they know and understand their responsibilities around registration and the conditions of their stay.
- 3.30 In evidenced and unforeseen circumstances, a candidate may apply to extend their registration. The first six months may be authorised by their Faculty Director of PGR candidates on behalf of the PGRCPSC. In exceptional circumstances the PGRCPSC may permit a further extension of up to 12 months.
- 3.31 Where the PGR candidate is prevented, by ill-health or other serious and evidenced cause, from making progress with the research, the candidate may make a request to intermit their studies for an initial period of up to a maximum of 6 months. This initial period of up to 6 months will be considered by the Faculty Director of PGR Candidates and reported to the PGRCPSC. Any further evidenced intermission requests will be considered by the PGRCPSC up to a maximum period of 18 months.
- 3.32 During intermission a PGR candidate's registration is suspended, and they will not receive academic supervision, but may be contacted to offer pastoral support.
- 3.33 Requests for maternity, paternity, shared parental or adoptive leave are considered additional to intermission time for other purposes and will be considered by the PGRCPSC. Relevant evidence (e.g. MATB1, birth certificate or matching certificate) should be supplied. Candidates are entitled to take up to 50 weeks parental / adoptive intermission within the year of birth / adoption. There is no limit to the number of periods of parental leave that can be taken.

Write-up Status

- 3.34 Candidates for all awards except PhD by Published Work may apply to the PGRCPSC to enter the writing-up status for up to 12 months, or the remaining period of registration (where shorter). Write up status can be entered on the first day of any month. Applications should not be retrospective.
- 3.35 Only in documented, exceptional and unforeseen circumstances will the PGRCPSC allow write-up status to be extended to a maximum of 24 months.
- 3.36 The candidate must have submitted their thesis for examination by the end of their writing-up status period or they will be discontinued.

- 3.37 PGR candidates must complete the application form in PGRPro confirming that:
- a for doctoral candidates, that they have completed upgrade of registration.
 - b it is viable for their thesis to be submitted within 12 months;
 - c they have submitted a substantial portion of their thesis to their First Supervisor;
 - d they have completed the minimum period of registration;
 - e they have completed all active research including lab work;
 - f they have completed all analysis of their data;
 - g they will not need access to university facilities such as laboratories, provision of a room or a desk. (N.B. On entering Write Up status PGR candidate's access to services are limited to the Library, IT facilities and the supervisory team);
 - h they have completed all compulsory researcher development activity and attended any compulsory workshops.
- 3.38 If, in exceptional cases, additional access is needed to studios, labs, workshops or other specialist facilities during Write Up status, written authorisation must be obtained in advance from the Faculty Director PGR candidates. This authorisation must specify the reason the access is required and the nature/extent and duration of the access. All requests granted must be reported to the next meeting of the PGRCPSC.

Holiday Entitlement

- 3.39 PGR candidates may take up to 35 working days holiday in each year (pro rata for parts of a year) inclusive of normal public holidays. The timing of their holidays must be agreed with their First Supervisor. Student visa holders must ensure the Faculty Research Administrator is informed of any leave so that it can be monitored in line with ARU's Tier 4 sponsorship duties.

Withdrawal of Registration/Discontinuation of Registration

- 3.40 The Faculty will inform the PGRCPSC when a candidate formally withdraws from their course.
- 3.41 The Faculty will discontinue a candidate and notify the PGRCPSC if they fail to re-register or pay fees.

- 3.42 The PGRCPSC may discontinue a PGR candidate if they fail to comply with any research degree regulation which makes specific requirements of them or who fails to make satisfactory academic progress as determined at a point of assessment.
- 3.43 The Faculty is responsible for monitoring their PGR candidates' progress. Where there is concern about progress or lack of contact, the case will be considered by PGRCPSC and an appropriate course of action determined that encourages progress and/or re-engagement. If the candidate fails to respond in a satisfactory manner, they will be discontinued.
- 3.44 Examples of failing to make academic progress include (the list is not exhaustive):
- a if the PGR candidate's period of registration has expired, and an application for extension of registration has not been submitted and approved;
 - b if the PGR candidate has not submitted their thesis on expiry of the Write Up Status phase;
 - c if, on resubmission, the PGR candidate has failed to submit a satisfactory, or any, Research Proposal, Annual Review or Upgrade of Registration;
 - d if the PGR candidate on a Professional Doctorate programme has exhausted all available attempts to pass the taught modules of the programme;
 - e if the PGR candidate has failed to submit a revised thesis for examination by their deadline.
 - f The PGRCPSC may discontinue a candidate for any other valid reason.

Other Requirements of Registration

- 3.45 All postgraduate research degree candidates are expected to be familiar with and comply with the following:
- a The University's [Rules, Regulations and Procedures for Students](#);
 - b The Research Ethics Policy, the Code of Practice for Applying for Ethical Approval at ARU and all relevant guidance e.g. relating to data protection.;
 - c Any other regulations, policies and procedures which affect them, such as health and safety, academic misconduct, research misconduct and intellectual property.

- d Candidates who have been recruited to a funded scholarship and/or collaborative project must be attentive to the requirements set out in the Agreements for funding and / or collaboration.

3.46 Candidates are responsible for:

- a Maintaining regular and frequent contact with their supervisory team and preparing appropriately for meetings with supervisors;
- b Initiating meetings with supervisors and retaining appropriate meeting records in PGRPro;
- c Planning and submitting work as and when required and maintaining satisfactory academic progress;
- d Complying with requirements of progression monitoring;
- e Ensuring all work is submitted in a fully accessible format;
- f Engaging with any relevant training that has been identified and agreed with supervisors as a result of skills needs analysis and / or supervisory team meetings;
- g Raising awareness of any specific needs or circumstances likely to affect either their studies or their timely completion.

3.47 Where a candidate does not meet their responsibilities, as outlined above, they may be subject to University procedures for managing unsatisfactory performance which may result in discontinuation of the candidate's studies.

SECTION 4. SUPERVISION

- 4.1 The primary role and responsibility of postgraduate research supervisors is to advise upon and guide candidates through the scholarly and technical processes that enable candidates to produce a thesis at the appropriate level. Supervisors are expected to be familiar with and adhere to all processes and procedures relating to research governance at ARU

The Supervisory Team

- 4.2 The supervisory team must have appropriate subject expertise and the necessary skills and experience to monitor, support and direct candidates' work.
- 4.3 A PGR candidate shall have two supervisors. One shall be designated First Supervisor with responsibility to supervise the candidate on a regular and frequent basis and to act as the principal point of contact and guide to the candidate on conduct, governance and administrative matters. Further supervisors may upon occasion be appointed where a strong justification for their inclusion is made.
- 4.4 PGR candidates should have regular supervisory meetings, documented in PGRPro. These should be at least monthly for full-time candidates, and bimonthly for part-time candidates, and include meetings with the whole team. For a Student Route sponsored candidate these meetings must be in person to satisfy visa requirements.
- 4.5 The Faculty Director of PGR Candidates, in conjunction with the Head of School, shall ensure teams are adjusted promptly when supervisors become unable to support the candidate.
- 4.6 The Head of School shall ensure that individual supervisors are not overloaded and inform the Faculty Director of Research Candidates if supervisors become unable to support the candidate.
- 4.7 The supervisory team must collectively meet all the following criteria. The First Supervisor would normally meet these criteria.
- a hold a doctoral award;
 - b have supervised a PGR candidate through to conferment at the level of the award being supervised. This supervision must have been for at least 50% of a PGR candidate's registration;

- c current engagement in research in the relevant discipline including peer reviewed publications;
- d have experience of internal or external examining at the level of the award being supervised.
- e All supervisors must attend ARU's Supervisor Training Session within six months of their first appointment to that role.
- f All supervisors employed by ARU and any Academic Partner are required to attend a supervisor CPD session at least once every two years. External supervisors are strongly encouraged to attend.
- g For candidates on the award Doctor of Medicine by Research, one member of the supervisory team must be a medical practitioner.

4.8 A third supervisor may not be used to meet the conditions stipulated above.

The First Supervisor

4.9 The First Supervisor shall be either:

- a a full-time or fractional member of the academic staff of ARU whose role includes full academic duties including research;
- b an Emeritus Professor or Emeritus Associate Professor of ARU, where this is in the best interest of the PGR candidates. They must be based in the UK and be research active;
- c a full-time or fractional member of the academic staff of Cambridge Theological Federation or any other Academic Partner where this arrangement has been agreed through the appropriate approval process.

Second Supervisors / Advisers

4.10 Nominations for appointment as second / exceptional further supervisors are considered from those that meet the criteria for first supervisors but may also include:

- a Members of academic and professional services staff including anybody who has a contract of employment with ARU specifically to undertake research supervision;

- b Visiting Professors can be nominated to act as a second or third supervisor (or as an adviser) during their period of appointment in the visiting role. Normally the visiting appointment should last for the expected duration of the PGR candidate's programme of research. A 'quarantine' period of three years after the termination of their visiting status will apply before they can be appointed as an external examiner.
- c Faculties may nominate, and pay for, an external supervisor where this is deemed necessary but they cannot act as the First Supervisor.

4.11 In addition to the supervisors, an adviser or advisers may be proposed to contribute some specialised knowledge or a link with an external organisation.

Exclusions from Supervisory Teams

4.12 In the appointment of supervisory teams any potential conflicts of interest should be avoided, such as family or close personal relationships within the team, or line management relationships between the candidate and first supervisor.

4.13 A candidate for a research degree, except those submitting for a PhD by Published Work, shall be ineligible to act as First Supervisor for another research degree candidate but may act as a second supervisor or adviser.

SECTION 5. THE POSTGRADUATE RESEARCHER DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMME AND OTHER TRAINING

- 5.1 PGR candidates are required by the University to attend the compulsory sessions of the Postgraduate Researcher Development Programme and are also expected to engage with the broader researcher development activity offered by the Doctoral School and Faculties. Candidates who are funded and / or recruited as part of wider collaborative projects may be required to attend further training as per their agreements.
- 5.2 All PGR candidates must complete a Research Skills Needs Analysis in PGRPro to establish their skills development needs and create a personal development plan. This must be regularly updated and considered as part of the process of Annual Review.
- 5.3 PGR candidates with an undergraduate medical qualification recognised by the General Medical Council in the UK may be exempt from ARU compulsory research ethics training, subject to providing evidence of an up-to-date ICH-Good Clinical Practice training record. ICH-Good Clinical Practice training needs to be renewed every two years. A copy of the training record must be provided to the Researcher Development Programme Administrator in the Doctoral School.
- 5.4 All PGR candidates who are engaged in undertaking teaching on any ARU modules and who have not received approved training for that teaching must attend the Learning and Teaching in Practice programme.

SECTION 6. PROGRESSION REVIEW ARRANGEMENTS

General

- 6.1 Progression of postgraduate research candidates in a timely manner towards successful completion will be monitored by the University.
- 6.2 All submissions, reports and decisions should be reported in PGRPro.
- 6.3 Additional or alternative special review or progress panels may be required for holders of ARU full or match-funded scholarship or fees only awards OR external scholarship or collaborative award.
- 6.4 Any candidate missing the submission deadline for progression events will be treated as a resubmission and be required to resubmit a final attempt within two months of notification.
- 6.5 Candidates must obtain an originality report through Turnitin and discuss with their First Supervisor prior to submission.
- 6.6 Submissions will be reviewed by a minimum of two suitably experienced academics, independent of the supervisory team, who have attended the relevant staff development provided by the Doctoral School. An external panel member should be sought where there is no ARU staff member other than the supervisory team with relevant knowledge. MD (Res) candidate assessment teams should include an appropriately qualified medical practitioner at Upgrade of Registration. The Faculty Director of PGR candidates shall be responsible for determining if an external panel member is required.
- 6.7 Reviewers will produce a joint report in PGRPro to support their outcome recommendation within 10 working days of their review. Their recommendations are considered by the PGRCPSC. Where reviewers are unable to reach a joint recommendation the submission, and the reviewer's reports, will be considered by the PGRCPSC which will reach a decision which is reported in PGRPro.
- 6.8 If a submission for a progression event is not approved at the first attempt the candidate is allowed one opportunity to revise and resubmit. For Research Proposal and Annual Review this must be within 2 months of notification by PGRCPSC; for Upgrade of Registration within 4 months for full-time candidates, 6 months for part-time candidates.

- 6.9 If a submission is not approved at second attempt a candidate is discontinued except in the case of:
- a An unsuccessful attempt at Upgrade of Registration where a Doctoral candidate is transferred to the appropriate Masters award (excepting MDRes candidates who are discontinued)
 - b Annual Review following successful Upgrade of Registration, where examiners may recommend change of registration to a Masters level award (excepting MDRes candidates who are discontinued). Maximum registration period will be adjusted pro rata.

Short-term extensions for academic assessments

- 6.10 PGR candidates may request a maximum of one short term extension to a submission deadline for submission of their Research Proposal, Upgrade of Registration or Annual Review when circumstances outside their control have arisen which prevents submission or is likely to result in significant underperformance if the original deadline is enforced.
- 6.11 The purpose of a short term extension is to allow the candidate, for acceptable reasons, to defer the submission and / or oral assessment. The work for assessment and / or oral presentation should be submitted and / occur within 10 working days of original deadline. Deadlines for subsequent academic assessments and the maximum period of registration will not be extended.
- 6.12 Faculty Directors of Research Candidates have delegated authority to approve a short term extension request, and will inform the Doctoral School so the adjustment is noted on the Candidate's record. Faculty Directors of Research Candidates are permitted to request, at their discretion, evidence to support the request.

The Research Proposal

- 6.13 The research proposal is a concise and coherent summary (<2,000 words) of the research being proposed for the award to which the student is registered. It outlines the general area of study, the current state of knowledge in the subject area and gap in knowledge that the research proposed intends to address. It should demonstrate the researcher has the aptitude for postgraduate level research, for instance by demonstrating the ability to communicate complex ideas clearly, concisely and critically. The researcher should demonstrate awareness of research ethics and integrity, and the steps involved in executing the proposed work in a timely manner. Due diligence should be paid to ARU's research ethics, integrity and health and safety guidance and adherence to relevant

procedures as appropriate. The proposal is the foundation from which the research and researcher will develop and be periodically assessed against the standards for the registered award.

- 6.14 MPhil, PhD and MD(Res) candidates should submit their proposal by the date advised on their PGRPro timeline, normally within 6 weeks after the course start date for full-time candidates, and 10 weeks for part-time candidates.
- 6.15 Professional Masters or Professional Doctorate candidates registering prior to September 2021 must seek approval of their Research Proposal normally no later than 24 months after the course start date. Candidates for these awards commencing their studies from September 2021 submit their Research Proposal as part of the taught modules of their award in line with the requirements in their module guide. Candidates for these awards are required to pass all modules in the taught stage and achieve a minimum mark of 60% in the relevant assessed element to progress to the Research Stage of their programme. Candidates who pass the element incorporating the Research Proposal but fail to reach the progression mark will be allowed a single opportunity to re-attempt the element to obtain qualifying mark for progression.
- 6.16 A PGR candidate who has had their Research Proposal approved and subsequently needs to change the focus and/or topic of their research must gain the support of their First Supervisor before applying to the PGRCPSC for re-approval using the procedure outlined in this Section. Subsequent regulatory deadlines will not be extended and, in such situations, it may be more appropriate for the PGR candidate to withdraw and reapply for admittance.

Research Ethics

- 6.17 PGR candidates must consider ethical issues at an early stage and should consult the Research Ethics Policy and relevant sections of the Code of Practice for Applying for Ethical Approval at ARU.
- 6.18 The Research Proposal must demonstrate the candidate's understanding of the potential ethical implications of their work and acknowledge the requirement to adhere to ARU's Research Ethics, Integrity and Health and Safety guidance and procedures as applicable to the research. The Research Proposal does not constitute applying for ethical approval, which is a separate process.

- 6.19 A research ethics application must be completed and submitted via ARU's online ethics system for core ARU students and using the 'paper based' process for students from Academic Partners. There may be further project specific governance checks or approvals required. It is the responsibility of PGR candidates to obtain these. The research must not commence until approval has been obtained. PGR candidates may need to apply for ethical approval on more than one occasion to cover different components of their research programme.

Annual Review

- 6.20 The purpose of Annual Review is for assessors check that candidates are progressing in an appropriate and timely manner through their research degree, producing relevant outputs, and have defined a suitable plan of work for the forthcoming year / to completion via a written progress report and meeting with the candidate. Assessors also monitor that the candidate is being supported through their attendance at supervisory meetings and engaging in researcher development opportunities.
- 6.21 Annual Review submission deadlines and the template for Annual Review are presented in PGRPro. Submission is typically required by the anniversary of their Registration, except
- a where a candidate has intermitted
 - b when candidates who have progressed through Upgrade of Registration as a first submission within that registration year
 - c for professional doctorate programme who are in the taught stage

Upgrade of Registration

- 6.22 Through the documentation submitted and a viva presentation, candidates should demonstrate to the assessors their consolidation of Level 7 skillsets, developing in a timely manner towards achievement of Level 8 as defined in the [QAA Doctoral Characteristics Statement](#). Ideally at this stage PGR candidates will have presented either posters and/or papers at appropriate research conferences.

- 6.23 Candidates are required to apply for upgrade of registration before the following deadlines:

		Initial registration date	
Award	Study Mode	Post Sept 2021	Prior to September 2021 Pre Sept 2019
PhD via MPhil, PhD (direct), MD (Res)	Full-time	12 months post initial registration	18 months post initial registration
	Part-time	18 months post initial registration	24 months post initial registration
Professional Doctorate (60 credit taught stage)	Part-time	24 months (post initial registration)	
Professional Doctorate (120 credit taught stage)	Part-time	36 months (post initial registration)	

Recommendations available to the Panel

- 6.24 At first attempt, the Panel may approve the application or recommend resubmission.
- 6.25 One resubmission is permitted within 4 months (for full-time candidates) and within six months (for part-time candidates) of the date of the letter notifying the candidate of the decision. In exceptional, and evidenced, circumstances these time limits may be extended by up to two further months by PGRCPSC.
- 6.26 If following resubmission the revised application for upgrade of registration is not approved, the candidate will:
- if enrolled on the PhD (direct) be transferred to MPhil and be subject to the applicable registration maxima;
 - if enrolled on the PhD via MPhil, remain on the MPhil and be subject to the applicable registration maxima;
 - if enrolled on a professional doctorate be transferred to MProf and be subject to the applicable registration maxima;
 - if enrolled on the MD (Res) be discontinued.

SECTION 7. THE EXAMINERS

- 7.1 Examiners should be proposed by the supervisory team no later than six months prior to the expected date for submission of the thesis, in consultation with the candidate.
- 7.2 Appointment of examiners must be approved by PGRCPSC or, in exceptional circumstances, the Chair acting on behalf of the PGRSPSC.
- 7.3 Additional or alternative arrangements may be required for funded candidates or those subject to collaborative agreements.
- 7.4 The Research Degrees Examinations Officer is responsible for formally contacting examiners following approval, and the subsequent arrangement of the examination. The PGR candidate shall not contact the proposed / appointed examiner(s) in relation to the examination of the thesis prior to the examination.
- 7.5 Normally, an external examiner shall examine no more than three PGR candidates over a period of three years at ARU.
- 7.6 A PGR candidate shall normally be examined by one external and one internal examiner in the presence of an independent neutral Chair who has attended appropriate training. Where more than two examiners are appointed, the majority are generally from outside ARU.
- 7.7 Where the PGR candidate is a member of staff of ARU¹, or an Academic Partner, there shall be two external examiners and no internal examiner. Where there are more than two external examiners, they should not be from the same Institution.
- 7.8 The examiners are responsible for making academic decisions about the candidate, the Chair can advise in terms of examination outcomes available to them within ARU's regulations.

Examiners' Experience

- 7.9 Examiners shall normally possess a doctorate, be experienced in research in the general area of the PGR candidate's thesis and, particularly in the case of external examiners, have experience as a specialist in the topic(s) to be examined.

¹ For the purposes of appointing their examiners, PGR candidates who have been employed on hourly-paid contracts are not considered as member of staff

- 7.10 The examining team shall have substantial experience of examining (at least three PGR candidates one of which must have been for a UK Higher Education Institution), and supervising to completion at, or above, the level of the award for which they have been appointed to.
- 7.11 It is the expectation that the examining team for a Professional Doctorate the examining team shall normally have relevant subject expertise and experience of examining for this award. Where this expectation cannot be satisfied PGRSPC may consider nomination of an otherwise appropriately qualified examining team on the proviso that a Chair with expertise in the requirements of the Professional Doctorate is appointed to ensure practice-based requirements have been considered by the examiners.
- 7.12 In an examination for a Doctor of Medicine by Research the examining team shall normally have experience of examining at least one Doctor of Medicine candidate, and one examiner must be an appropriately qualified medical practitioner. In cases where examiners with experience of examining Doctor of Medicine by Research cannot be appointed, PGRSPC may approve an otherwise appropriately qualified examining team on the proviso that a Chair with expertise in the requirements of the award is appointed to ensure the requirements of the award have been considered by the examiners.
- 7.13 An external examiner shall be independent of ARU, Academic Partner and / or the candidate i.e. not have been involved in any collaborative and / or contractual project or personal relationship with the candidate or their supervisors in the previous three years.
- 7.14 Former members of staff including those holding visiting status, or doctoral candidates of ARU may be appointed as external examiners provided that a period of at least three years has passed since completing their employment / award.
- 7.15 No current or past supervisor can be appointed as an examiner for that PGR candidate.
- 7.16 An external supervisor for an ARU research award candidate is not eligible to act as an external examiner for any PGR candidates during the term of their supervisory appointment or for three years after the end of their period of appointment.
- 7.17 If any one of the above criteria cannot be met, the First Supervisor must submit a rationale outlining the examiner's particular suitability for consideration by the PGRCPSC.

7.18 An internal examiner shall be defined as an examiner who is:

- a a member of staff of ARU or Academic Partner or;
- b a member of staff of the PGR candidate's collaborating establishment or;
- c an Emeritus Professor or Reader of ARU as long as they are still research active or;
- d a Visiting Professor of ARU.

7.19 Former PGR candidates of ARU may be appointed as internal examiners if they have not been supervised by a past or present member of the PGR candidate's supervisory team.

SECTION 8. THE THESIS

Presentation of the Thesis

- 8.1 The PGR candidate shall ensure that the format and presentation of the written thesis, as submitted for examination is in accordance with the Guidance on the Presentation and Submission of Theses for Research Degree Awards. For submissions involving creative or scholarly works please also refer to the section below.
- 8.2 The thesis title is approved when the PGRCPSC appoints the examiners. Any request to change the title after this point must be made in writing to the PGRCPSC and before the thesis is submitted for the viva.
- 8.3 Permission to present a thesis, and be examined, in a language other than English shall normally be sought at the time of application to the University. Subsequent requests require the approval of PGRCPSC. Permission shall normally only be given if the subject matter of the thesis involves language and related studies and a summary in English of up to 1000 words must be included in the thesis.

Submissions Including Creative or Scholarly Works

- 8.4 Where a PGR candidate has completed a programme of research in which their own creative work or production of scholarly work forms a substantive part of the intellectual enquiry, the final presentation may be partly in other than written form. Such work shall have been undertaken as part of the registered research programme.
- 8.5 The nature of the submission should be discussed with the Doctoral School no later than at the appointment of examiners so that appropriate arrangements can be made for the examination. The submission will comprise the creative work or scholarly texts including a permanent record of the work in digital format (e.g. video, photographic record, musical score, diagrammatic representation, artefacts, scholarly text) and an associated critical commentary which sets the work within its relevant theoretical, scholarly or design context. Textual and explanatory annotation should be included where appropriate.

Maximum Word Limits

8.6 The main text of the thesis should not exceed the following length:

Award	Discipline Area	Length
MPhil	Science, Engineering	30,000 words
MPhil	Arts, Health, Education, Social Sciences, Business, Law, Medicine, Medical Science	60,000 words
MPhil	Submissions incorporating portfolio of Creative of Scholarly Works – written commentary	20,000 words
PhD	Science, Engineering	60,000 words
PhD	Arts, Health, Education, Social Sciences, Business, Law, Medicine, Medical Science	80,000 words
PhD	Submissions incorporating portfolio of Creative of Scholarly Works – written commentary	40,000
MD by Research	Medicine	50,000 words
Professional Master's	All	40,000* words
Professional Doctorate	All	60,000* words
*Professional Doctorate and Professional Masters commencing their studies prior to September 2016 should refer to the 22 nd edition (September 2022) of the Research Degrees Regulations.		

8.7 Applications to exceed these word limits must be made to the PGRCPSC before submission and will normally only be considered if within 10 percent of the word limits specified above.

8.8 Following examination and the incorporation of any amendments which the examiners require, the PGR candidate will submit final versions in the thesis in line with the Guidance on the Presentation of Theses for the Award of Research Degrees. This copy will be:

- a Checked by the PGR and their supervisory team and confirmed as being in a format accessible to all potential readers in accordance with UK law;
- b Submitted within one calendar month of the e-mail notifying the PGR candidate of the decision of the PGRCPSC;

- c Accompanied by the completed Thesis Deposit Agreement Form which confirms agreement for the thesis to be published in the institutional repository and for it to be 'harvested' from there by the British Library for inclusion in their British universities theses database, EThOS (Electronic Theses Online Service).
- d Once the thesis is deposited digitally the copyright agreement in the Thesis Deposit Agreement Form will come into effect.

Copyright

- 8.9 Copyright in theses is normally held by the PGR candidate unless an agreement has been made to transfer it, for example to a sponsor.

Embargo

- 8.10 Where a PGR candidate or ARU wishes the thesis to remain under limited access, an embargo application should be made at the time of seeking approval of the examiners from the PGRCPSC.
- 8.11 A thesis shall not be embargoed to protect research leads. PGRCPSC will normally only approve an embargo application for one (or more) of the following reasons:
- a in order to enable a patent application to be lodged;
 - b in order to publish, or obtain a contract to publish, the thesis in whole or in part;
 - c the thesis contains politically sensitive material;
 - d conditions imposed by a sponsor;
 - e where the PGR candidate has been unable to obtain, or is unable to pay for, permission to use third party copyright material;
 - f the thesis contains commercially sensitive information, the release of which might prejudice the commercial interests of any person including the author, the University or an external company;
 - g the thesis includes material that was obtained under a promise of confidentiality;
 - h placing the thesis in the public domain might endanger the physical or mental health or the safety of an individual;

- i placing the thesis in the public domain would cause the author or third parties mentioned in the text to be open to legal challenge or persecution;
- j publication would cause the PGR candidate or third parties mentioned in the text to be open to legal challenge or persecution.
- k publication would cause the PGR candidate or third parties mentioned in the text to be open to legal challenge or persecution.

8.12 PGR candidates should consider before any application that:

- a The starting assumption is always that research can be made publicly available;
- b An embargo should not be used as an alternative to legitimate ways of anonymising data to protect participants;
- c Sensitive material can be removed to an appendix and embargoed separately so that the main body of research is still available publicly;
- d PGR candidates should be following good practice in these areas (regardless of electronic access);
- e Issues relating to potential harm to individuals or the author should be considered as part of the research design, the ethical approval process and the risk assessment (health and safety).

8.13 ARU is a designated public authority under the Freedom of Information Act 2000. This Act gives a general right of access to all information held by the University, including information held in our on-line repository ARRO. As a normal matter of practice we will only make a thesis available in accordance with any embargo we have agreed. However, if someone specifically asks to see a thesis, we must give them access unless it qualifies for an exemption under the Act.

8.14 While the normal maximum period for a temporary embargo is three years from the date of oral examination but should be shorter where adequate. In exceptional circumstances the PGRCPSC may approve a longer period. Requests for an exceptional permanent embargo are considered only on the grounds of sensitivity or confidentiality of content.

8.15 For the period of any agreed embargo the thesis will not be made available in ARU Library (ARRO), or any library at a collaborating establishment or Academic Partner (s). The thesis shall be retained by ARU on restricted access and, shall only be made available to those who were directly involved in the project.

SECTION 9. EXAMINATION OF THE THESIS AND VIVA VOCE EXAMINATION

Assessment Criteria for Postgraduate Research Degrees

- 9.1 Through the examination of the thesis and the viva voce examination, examiners must be satisfied that the candidate and their research meet the criteria for the award for which they are registered including:
- a identification and execution of a suitable postgraduate research topic
 - b successful completion of a programme of training in research techniques and methodology (including, where appropriate, conformity with the ethics, legal and safety requirements, as set out by ARU);
 - c satisfactory knowledge of the background literature and is able to relate the project to existing scholarship and research in the field;
 - d a thesis that is clearly their own work and is presented in a satisfactory manner (grammar, punctuation, spelling, clarity of expression, logical argument and appropriate language) and contains technical apparatus (abstract, preface and acknowledgements, footnotes, references, appendices, statistical tables, diagrams, illustrations, bibliography) set out according to the conventions of the field of study;
- 9.2 Candidates submitting a Masters level thesis should display appropriate evidence of:
- a originality and independent critical judgement and;
 - b demonstrates an understanding of research methods appropriate to the chosen field;
- 9.3 Candidates submitting a Doctoral level thesis should display evidence of:
- a originality and independent critical judgement;
 - b a contribution to subject knowledge in the research field;
- 9.4 Candidates for the award of MD(Res) in addition should indicate how their findings advance clinical medicine and their capacity to make objective autonomous judgements in complex situations in their clinical field;

- 9.5 Candidate for the awards of the Professional Doctorate and Professional Master's should reflect on and examine critically their own professional activity, research in accordance with academic and professional standards, and indicate their contribution to Professional Practice and development of professional competencies including, where appropriate, autonomous and/or collaborative initiative in planning and implementing tasks at a professional or equivalent level.

Submission of the Thesis

- 9.6 The Doctoral School will make known to the PGR candidate the procedure to be followed for the submission of the thesis and any conditions to be satisfied before the candidate may be considered eligible for the examination or subsequent award.
- 9.7 The PGR candidate is responsible for deciding whether to submit the thesis for examination. The candidate should take account of the opinion of the supervisory team, which is advisory. An opinion that the thesis is ready for submission does not guarantee that a degree will be awarded. The decision to award a degree rest wholly with the examining team.
- 9.8 Where the PGRCPSC has approved a PGR candidate's request for an embargo of the thesis, the examiners and the independent Chair are required to sign a Confidentiality Agreement and to return copies of the thesis to the PGR candidate at the conclusion of the examination. These obligations do not apply to any information which is public knowledge at the time of its disclosure.

SECTION 10. EXAMINATION

- 10.1 All postgraduate research examinations consist of two parts:
- a Examination of the thesis
 - b Oral defence of the thesis (viva voce)
- 10.2 The viva voce examination must take place within 3 calendar months, and normally not less than one month, of the examiners receiving the thesis, preliminary report form and Notes of Guidance (to give examiners a reasonable period to assess the work). PGR candidates are required to attend the viva voce examination on the agreed date unless there are exceptional and unforeseen circumstances which prevent attendance.
- 10.3 Additional or alternative arrangements may be required for funded candidates or those subject to collaborative agreements.

Preliminary Report on the Thesis

- 10.4 Each examiner will read the thesis and provide an independent Preliminary Report on it to the University before any oral or alternative form of examination is held. In completing the Preliminary Report, each examiner shall consider whether the thesis provisionally satisfies the requirements of the degree and where possible shall make an appropriate provisional recommendation subject to the outcome of an oral examination.
- 10.5 The Doctoral School will ensure that all examiners Preliminary Reports are distributed to the examination team prior to the viva. Examiners are required to keep the Preliminary Reports confidential prior to the viva and any breach of confidentiality will invalidate the examination.
- 10.6 The Preliminary Reports will be shared with supervisors once the viva commences. Supervisors will receive the examiner's Final Report when the latter is sent to the candidate.

The Oral Examination

- 10.7 The oral examination may be held face to face (on ARU or Academic Partner premises) or by video-conference, subject to the agreement and adherence of all parties to the Guidance on the use of Videoconferencing for examination of PGR theses. PGR Candidates may give a 10 minute presentation at the start of their oral examination.

- 10.8 Up to two members of the supervisory team and the Chair of the RDC may, with the consent of the PGR candidate, attend the oral examination as observers, but shall withdraw prior to the deliberations of the examiners on the outcome of the examination.

Recommendations available to Examiners

- 10.9 Following the completion of the oral or approved alternative examination the examiners may recommend that:
- a the PGR candidate may be awarded the degree;
 - b the PGR candidate be awarded the degree subject to minor amendments and corrections being made to the thesis
 - c the PGR candidate be awarded the degree subject to amendments and corrections being made to the thesis
 - d the PGR candidate is referred to re-submit for the degree and be re-examined with an oral examination;
 - e the PGR candidate is referred to re-submit for the degree and be re-examined without an oral examination;
 - f in the case of a PhD examination, the PGR candidate be awarded the degree of MPhil subject to the presentation of the thesis amended to the satisfaction of the examiners and which must meet the criteria for the award of MPhil (this recommendation can only be treated as an amendment)
 - g in the case of a DProf examination, the PGR candidate be awarded the degree of MProf subject to the presentation of the thesis amended to the satisfaction of the examiners and which must meet the criteria for the award of MProf (this recommendation can only be treated as an amendment);
 - h in the case of a PhD examination, the PGR candidate be permitted to re-submit for the degree of MPhil with an oral examination;
 - i in the case of a DProf examination, the PGR candidate be permitted to re-submit for the degree of MProf with an oral examination;
 - j in the case of a PhD examination, the PGR candidate be permitted to re-submit for the degree of MPhil without an oral examination;

- k in the case of a DProf examination, the PGR candidate be permitted to re-submit for the degree of MProf without an oral examination;
 - l the PGR candidate be not awarded the degree and be not permitted to be re-examined.
- 10.10 The examiners shall inform the PGR candidate of their recommendation to the PGRCPSC but must make it clear that the final decision rests with the PGRCPSC.

Award of the Degree Subject to Amendments to the Thesis

- 10.11 Where the examiners are satisfied that the PGR candidate has in general reached the standard required for the degree, but consider that the PGR candidate's thesis requires additional explanatory information or some amendments and corrections not so substantial as to call for the examination of a revised thesis, they may recommend that the degree be awarded subject to the PGR candidate amending and re-presenting the thesis to the satisfaction of the internal and/or the external examiner(s). They shall indicate to the PGR candidate in writing what amendments and corrections are required within ten working days of the oral examination. The PGR candidate should be able to undertake amendments to fulfil the criteria for the award for which they are registered with minimal supervision.
- 10.12 Minor amendments should be completed within three months of the date the examiners' feedback is sent to them. The PGRCPSC may, where there are exceptional reasons, approve an extension of this period. Minor corrections that are permissible include typographical errors, minor amendments and/or replacement of, or additions to the text, references or diagrams.
- 10.13 Where the candidate has met the criteria for the award, but more substantive inclusions, restructuring or re-analysis is required to fully reflect the quality of the research undertaken, the PGR candidate must re-present the corrected thesis within a maximum of six months from the date the examiner's feedback is sent to the candidate.
- 10.14 The PGRCPSC may, in exceptional circumstances, approve an extension to the period permitted for amendments.
- 10.15 PGR candidates should attach a summary of the changes they have made identifying where the changes can be found in the corrected thesis.

Other Outcomes

- 10.16 Where a master's level outcome is recommended for a thesis submitted for a Doctoral award, the PGR candidate must submit the amended thesis within a maximum of 6 months from the date the examiners' feedback is sent to them.
- 10.17 Where the thesis is referred for resubmission, the PGR candidate must submit the amended thesis within a maximum of 12 months from the date the examiners' feedback is sent to them.
- 10.18 Where the PGRCPSC accepts the recommendation that the degree be not awarded and that no re-examination be permitted, the examiners shall prepare an agreed statement of the deficiencies of the thesis and the reason for their recommendation, which shall be forwarded to the candidate by the Research Degrees Examination Officer.

Examiners' Action following the Examination

- 10.19 Following the oral examination the examiners shall, where they are in agreement, submit to the Research Degrees Examination Officer a joint report, list of amendments and corrections required and recommendation relating to the award of the degree within 10 working days. The reports and list of amendments shall provide sufficiently detailed comments on the scope and quality of the work to enable the PGRCPSC to satisfy itself that their recommendation is appropriate. These will be supplied to the PGR candidate by the Research Degrees Examination Officer within 5 days of receipt.
- 10.20 Where the examiners' recommendations are not unanimous following consultation, separate reports and recommendations shall be submitted. The Faculty Director of PGR Candidates is invited to nominate an additional external examiner to consider the thesis. This nomination is considered by the Chair of the PGRCPSC for approval by Chair's action.
- 10.21 Where an additional external examiner is appointed, they shall prepare an independent report based on the thesis and a further oral examination. The additional examiner will not be informed of the recommendations of the other examiners. The reports from all the examiners are considered by the Chair of the PGRCPSC or the full Subcommittee itself.

Referral for Resubmission

- 10.22 Where referred by the examiners, PGR candidates are normally allowed one opportunity to revise the thesis and be re-examined.
- 10.23 The PGR candidate shall normally submit for revised thesis within 12 months from the date the examiners' feedback is sent to them with a summary of the changes they have made identifying where the changes can be found in the resubmitted thesis. The PGRCPSC may, where there are good reasons, approve an extension of the resubmission period.
- 10.24 The PGRCPSC may require that additional or replacement external examiners are appointed for the re-examination. The submission of the revised thesis, the re-examination process and the approval of the examiners appointments shall be conducted in accordance with the timescales and requirements of the first examination. Examiners are required to submit their preliminary report on the thesis:
- a at least 10 working days before any oral examination where there is a viva;
 - b within 25 working days of receiving the thesis where there is no viva.

Outcomes on Re-Examination

- 10.25 Following completion of the re-examination the examiners may recommend that:
- a the PGR candidate be awarded the degree;
 - b the PGR candidate be awarded the degree subject to minor amendments being made to the thesis;
 - c in the case of a PhD examination, the PGR candidate be awarded the degree of MPhil with or without minor amendments and which must meet the criteria for the award of MPhil;
 - d in the case of a DProf examination, the PGR candidate be awarded the degree of MProf with or without minor amendments and which must meet the criteria for the award of MProf
 - e the PGR candidate be failed without the possibility of re-submission
 - f the PGR candidate be exceptionally referred to re-submit the thesis for a second time.

- 10.26 The PGRCPSC may decide, on the recommendation of the examiners preliminary report, that the degree be not awarded and that no further re-examination be permitted. This may be recommended where the examiners are independently of the opinion that no useful purpose would be served by conducting an oral examination. In such cases, the examiners shall prepare an agreed statement of the deficiencies of the thesis and the reason for their recommendation, which shall be forwarded to the candidate by the Research Degrees Examination Officer.

Aegrotat Awards

- 10.27 At the discretion of the Postgraduate Research Degrees Progression Subcommittee an application for consideration for award by aegrotat may be permitted where a candidate is prevented by illness or other special evidenced circumstance from completing the final assessed elements of their award.
- 10.28 The supervisory team must consider whether there is a sufficient quantity of material to represent the thesis (a full thesis; partially complete thesis; draft thesis chapters; draft publications; any related documentation which would have been incorporated into the thesis; any other supporting information e.g. progress reports). The supervisor/s must be satisfied that there is enough to permit an academic judgement to be made.
- 10.29 The supervisory team must provide a statement of written support for the application, including a rationale for why they feel the degree should be awarded.
- 10.30 If the candidate is not well enough to make the application the first supervisor will prepare the work on their behalf but should not add to or enhance the work. The first supervisor will be required to confirm that the work is the candidate's own.
- 10.31 To be eligible for an aegrotat award the candidate;
- a must have successfully completed Upgrade of Registration,
 - b have demonstrated evidence of progress following Upgrade of Registration, that indicates they would have been likely to achieve the appropriate level of knowledge, understanding and skills to merit conferment of the award.
- 10.32 Examiners will be appointed in line with the Regulations and the examination of evidence provided must proceed in line with normal processes excepting any oral examination, corrections or revisions will not be required.

Posthumous awards

- 10.33 The degree of Professional Master's, MPhil, PhD, MD (Res) or a Professional Doctorate may be awarded posthumously on the basis of a thesis completed by a candidate who is ready for submission for examination. In such cases the PGRCPSC shall seek evidence that the candidate would have been likely to have been successful had the oral examination taken place before submitting a formal recommendation to the Academic Registrar for the attention of the Senate.

Conferment of the Award

- 10.34 Conferment of an award is withheld from any PGR candidate who has not fulfilled a legitimate requirement of ARU, including the settlement of any outstanding debt to ARU or to an Academic Partner at which the PGR candidate has studied in partial or complete fulfilment of the academic requirements of the course for which the PGR candidate is registered.
- 10.35 ARU provides an award certificate to each PGR candidate on whom it confers an award. Such certificates record:
- a the name of ARU;
 - b the full name of the PGR candidate as entered on ARU's Student Record System. It is the responsibility of the PGR candidate to ensure that his/her name is correctly entered;
 - c the award title as defined in the Research Degrees Regulations;
 - d the thesis title;
 - e the month and year that the PGRCPSC, or Chair, endorses the recommendation to confer the award;
 - f subject to the prior approval of the Senate, the name of any Academic Partner with whom ARU has collaborated in relation to the named award; [NB: this currently does not apply to any Academic Partner];
 - g a reference to the existence of a transcript for taught module results for Professional Doctorate awards.
- 10.36 The certificate bears the signature of the Vice-Chancellor.

- 10.37 The Academic Registrar is responsible for the provision of all award certificates, prepared in secure conditions and in a format designed to minimise the risk of forgery.
- 10.38 The Academic Registrar is responsible for maintaining a record of the names of all recipients of an academic award conferred by ARU.
- 10.39 Following the conferment of the award the graduand is invited by the Academic Registry's Assessment Service to attend a graduation ceremony.
- 10.40 For PGR candidates registered for a Professional Doctorate award, ARU provides a transcript of taught Stage 1 performance. The transcript contains:
- a the full name of the PGR candidate as entered on ARU's Student Record System. It is the responsibility of the student to ensure that this information is correctly entered;
 - b the award title as defined in the Research Degrees Regulations;
 - c a record of the outcome of every module in which the PGR candidate has been assessed (whether or not the PGR candidate has passed the module) with details of the module title, level, credit volume, module result and date of completion;
 - d where appropriate, the award conferred on the PGR candidate. This may be an intermediate award rather than the award for which the PGR candidate was originally registered;
 - e the date of publication of the transcript;
 - f the name of any Academic Partner with whom ARU has collaborated in relation to the named award;
 - g a reference to the language of assessment for the award if this is not English.

Retracting an Award

- 10.41 On rare occasions, it may become apparent that an ARU award has been conferred on a PGR candidate who was admitted to ARU based on forged documents, or who has gained an unfair advantage in some other way. Alternatively, some other form of deception may have occurred.

- 10.42 If such evidence comes to light, the matter is referred to the Secretary and Clerk who considers the evidence and is responsible for determining whether a case exists against the holder of the award. Where the Secretary and Clerk considers there to be insufficient evidence, the matter is dropped and no further action is taken.
- 10.43 If the Secretary and Clerk considers that a case does exist, he/she discusses the matter with the Vice-Chancellor who together determine the most appropriate action to take. In reaching this decision, the Vice-Chancellor and Secretary & Clerk consider the need to maintain the integrity and reputation of ARU's awards and academic standards. Such action can include the retraction of any or all awards already conferred by ARU and formal notification of such action to relevant Professional Statutory and Regulatory Bodies. The Academic Registrar maintains a record of such decisions and these are reported to the next scheduled meeting of the Senate.

SECTION 11. PGR BEHAVIOUR AND CONDUCT

- 11.1 As an academic community, ARU recognises that the principles of truth, honesty and mutual respect are central to the pursuit of knowledge. Behaviour that undermines these principles weakens the community, both individually and collectively, and diminishes ARU's values. Students who are in breach of the [Rules, Regulations and Procedures for Students](#) may be liable to disciplinary action under ARU's Student Disciplinary Procedure or an Academic Partner's equivalent procedures.
- 11.2 ARU recognises the importance of a safe community for our academic community of students and staff. All students should read and follow the [Harassment and Sexual misconduct policies and procedures](#) which can be found in this single comprehensive source of information.
- 11.3 Any alleged misconduct in research (that is, other than academic misconduct in an assessment) will be initially dealt with through the processes outlined in the [Guidance for the Investigation of Allegations of Misconduct in Research](#). If the case cannot be informally resolved, it will progress to a Stage 2 Panel Hearing as outlined below.

Management of Misconduct Allegations

- 11.4 This section describes ARU's policy for managing an alleged academic assessment offence by ARU PGR candidates, except for Professional Doctorate Candidates in the taught stage of their programme where the procedure in the [Academic Regulations](#) is applied.
- 11.5 An "assessment offence" is the generic term used to define cases where a PGR candidate(s) has sought to gain unfair academic advantage in the assessment process for him/herself or another PGR candidate(s) and/or not complied with internal or external ethical approval processes or breached a principle of research integrity.
- 11.6 There are many forms of assessment offence including (this is not an exhaustive list):
- a impersonating another PGR candidate;
 - b submitting someone else's work as one's own (known as "plagiarism": see below for a definition);

- c submitting unattributed work of your own that has already been used to gain a previous award (known as “self-plagiarism”);
- d the unauthorised and unattributed submission of an assessment item which has been produced by another PGR candidate or person;
- e the behaviour of one or more PGR candidates which may result in the poor academic performance of another PGR candidate(s);
- f any attempt to bribe or provide inducements to members of ARU staff, or to internal or external examiners in relation to the assessment process in its entirety
- g any attempt which, if enacted, is designed to undermine or breach the Research Degrees Regulations.

11.7 Plagiarism is the submission of an item of assessment containing elements of work produced by another person(s) in such a way that it could be assumed to be the PGR candidate’s own work. Examples of plagiarism are:

- a the verbatim copying of another person’s work without acknowledgement;
- b the close paraphrasing of another person’s work by simply changing a few words or altering the order of presentation without acknowledgement;
- c the unacknowledged quotation of phrases from another person’s work and/or the presentation of another person’s idea(s) as one’s own;
- d Copying or close paraphrasing with occasional acknowledgement of the source may also be deemed to be plagiarism if the absence of quotation marks implies the phraseology is the candidate’s own.

11.8 Plagiarised work may belong to another candidate or be (purchased) from a published source such as a book, report, journal or material available on the internet.

11.9 Collusion occurs when two or more individuals collaborate to produce a piece of work submitted (in whole or in part) for assessment and the work is presented as the work of one candidate alone.

Stage 1: Investigation of an Academic Misconduct Allegation

- 11.10 Where a Supervisor, progression event assessor or Examiner is concerned that an academic assessment offence has been committed, the case is referred to the Faculty Director of PGR Candidates, who will determine if there is sufficient evidence of misconduct, within 5 working days. The assessment in progress will be suspended whilst investigations take place.
- 11.11 Within 10 working days of referral, the Faculty Director of Research Students will send a formal notification to the student which:
- a Reports the facts of the allegation, stating the category of academic misconduct as outlined below
 - b Details the specifics of the alleged academic misconduct, including copies of any relevant documentary evidence
 - c Details the next stages of the investigation

Category	Definition
Very Minor	May include small errors in correctly applying referencing, attribution or paraphrasing conventions. Examples include: Citations and references are included where appropriate, but the correct referencing conventions have not been applied; Occasional word-for-word copying of short phrases or close paraphrasing of sentences from another source, with in-text attribution to the source material included.
Minor	Misconduct where the majority of the work should still be evident as the student's own if the inauthentic material were removed. There may be inadequate application of referencing, attribution or paraphrasing conventions or of independent working expectations. Examples include: Occasional instances of poorly paraphrased or closely copied work, without in-text attribution of the source material; Several instances of poorly paraphrased or closely copied work, with attribution to the source material; Similarities with another student's work which suggests that ideas were shared to an inappropriate extent.

Moderate	Misconduct where a significant part of the work is inauthentic but the student's own work is evident and is of comparable or greater significance. There may be a significant failure to apply referencing, attribution or paraphrasing conventions or of independent working expectations. Examples include: Significant use of poorly paraphrased work, whether attributed to the source material or not; Copying of numerous sentences from other sources, whether attributed to the source material or not; Source material which contributes significantly to the work is not acknowledged; Similarities with another student's work which suggests that materials or analyses were shared to an inappropriate extent.
Major	Misconduct where the inauthentic material forms a substantive or majority part of the work. Referencing, attribution or paraphrasing conventions, examination regulations or independent working expectations might be substantially breached. Examples include: Substantial used of poorly paraphrased or copied work, whether attributed to the source material or not. Source material/s which contribute substantially to the work or provide the basis for the work is not acknowledged. Similarities with another student's work which suggests that the work was produced by one student and copied by another or that the work was produced jointly.
Severe	Exceptionally serious misconduct includes: The purchasing of work prepared by another individual; Falsifying data Impersonation.

11.12 If the Faculty Director of Research Students believes misconduct under the minor to moderate classifications has occurred and this is the first alleged offence; they will:

- a Summons the student to a meeting to explain where the academic misconduct has occurred as part of an educative approach to avoiding future academic misconduct
- b Consider and respond to the student's response to the allegation.

- 11.13 If following the meeting the Faculty Director of Research Students is satisfied that misconduct has not occurred, they will inform the Doctoral School who will write to the student confirming the outcome of the investigation and that the process of assessment has recommenced.
- 11.14 If following the meeting the Faculty Director of Research Students is satisfied that misconduct under the minor to moderate classifications has occurred, they will inform the Doctoral School who will write to the student confirming the outcome of the investigation.
- a If the alleged misconduct is part of a first submission for a progression event, adjustments to the documents to address the elements of concern must be satisfactorily addressed as part of the resubmission
 - b If the alleged misconduct is part of a resubmission, assessors should consider the misconduct as part of their overall view of the work and their recommended outcome. The alleged assessment offence will be drawn to the attention of the PGRSPC when considering assessor recommendations.
- 11.15 If the Faculty Director of Research Students believes there is a case to answer under the major or severe classifications, and/ or this is a second allegation of an assessment offence, they will refer the matter to the Academic Registrar for further investigation.
- 11.16 On receipt of a suspected offence under the major or severe classifications, the Academic Registrar nominates, within 5 working days, an Investigating Officer from amongst the RDC membership, who is independent of the Faculty in which the PGR candidate is registered. The Investigating Officer is responsible for determining if there is sufficient evidence that an assessment offence has occurred and in so doing, determines the nature of the formal allegation to be put to the PGR candidate (e.g.: plagiarism, collusion etc.). In reaching this conclusion, the Investigating Officer presents his/her findings to the Academic Registrar, within 10 working days of being nominated to investigate the case. If they believe no offence has occurred, no further action is taken. If there is a case to answer, the allegation is put to the candidate by the Academic Registrar within 5 working days of receiving the Investigating Officer's findings.
- 11.17 The PGR candidate is required to respond to the Academic Registrar within 10 working days of notice or the candidate is deemed as not contesting the allegation. If the candidate denies the allegation a Stage 2 Panel is convened within 40 working days. If the candidate admits the allegation, the appropriate penalty is applied.

Stage 2: Panel Hearing

- 11.18 The Academic Registry is responsible for convening and minuting Stage 2 Panel Hearings. For Academic offences membership of the Panel comprises:
- a two members of the RDC who members of are not of the Faculty in which the PGR candidate is registered, and have not acted as the Investigating Officer (one of whom may act as chair). In the event of unavoidable absence the Panel may proceed with one member, providing the Candidate agrees, to reduce inconvenience to the candidate;
 - b a member of ARU's Academic Regulations Subcommittee;
 - c a PGR candidate from another Faculty nominated by the president of the Students' Union, in consultation with the Executive Secretary
- 11.19 For Research Misconduct cases referred having progressed through the processes outlined in the [Guidance for the Investigation of Allegations of Misconduct in Research](#) the membership of the Panel comprises:
- a One member of the RDC and one FREP Chair who are not members of the Faculty to which the PGR candidate is registered and have not been involved in the initial investigation
 - b A member of ARU's Academic Regulations Subcommittee;
 - c a PGR candidate from another Faculty nominated by the president of the Students' Union, in consultation with the Executive Secretary
- 11.20 In addition, the following have the right to be in attendance:
- a the President of the Students' Union (or an elected representative of the Students' Union).
 - b the presenter of the case (Dean of Faculty or nominee).
 - c the PGR candidate whose case is being heard and his/her friend or a representative of the Students' Union.
- 11.21 Neither ARU nor the PGR candidate are legally represented during the conduct of a hearing.

- 11.22 The Hearing is formal and operates in accordance with the procedure set out in the [Academic Regulations](#). It will take place no later than 40 working days after the PGR candidate has responded to deny the formal allegation. The report is submitted to PGRCPSC as a formal recommendation to implement the outcome, and a report is submitted to RDC for information.

Penalties

- 11.23 Where an allegation of an assessment offence or serious misconduct in research has been proved or admitted, the Academic Registrar, following consultation with the Deputy Vice-Chancellor (Research and Innovation), recommends to the Vice-Chancellor that the student be expelled from ARU. A PGR candidate who is expelled is not entitled to receive an intermediate award of any nature. For courses which attract academic credit, a transcript detailing the academic credit attained is issued.
- 11.24 If during the process the PGR candidate provides evidence of extenuating circumstances that he/she asserts directly led to the assessment offence being committed, such information does NOT impact on the Investigating Officer's findings or the Panel's decision. However, if the Investigating Officer or the Panel believes that, as a result of the extenuating circumstances, the prescribed penalty is exceptionally inappropriate they can, at their discretion, refer the matter to the Academic Registrar for discussion with the Deputy Vice-Chancellor (Research and Innovation), to review the appropriateness of the penalty. Such referrals must be considered within 10 working days.
- 11.25 All assessment or research misconduct offences are formally notified to the student at the conclusion of the process, in writing, by the Academic Registrar. Such notifications are sent within 20 working days of notification of the conclusion of the process by the Academic Registry.

Academic Appeals

- 11.26 In this section of the Regulations all references to 'the Academic Registrar' should be taken to include 'or nominee', all references to 'Director of PGR Candidates' should be taken to include 'or equivalent' and all references to the Chair of the PGRCPSC should be taken to include 'or nominee'.
- 11.27 All appeals, including those from PGR candidates registered at UK and international Academic Partner are administered by ARU. Appeals from PGR candidates registered at international Academic Partner may require special arrangements to administer the appeal.

- 11.28 This appeals procedure is also open to relevant former PGR candidates. In this instance 'former' means an appellant who lodges their appeal within 20 working days from the date of their award as specified on their notification of award letter.
- 11.29 In dealing with an academic appeal, privacy and confidentiality are assured unless disclosure is necessary to progress the appeal.
- 11.30 All parties are expected to act reasonably and fairly towards each other, and to treat the processes with respect. If the behaviour of an appellant becomes threatening or abusive during the course of the internal resolution process or a Panel Hearing, then the Academic Registrar or Panel Chair respectively is empowered to suspend the process and refer the matter to the Secretary & Clerk under the disciplinary procedures contained within the Rules, Regulations and Procedures for Students. The appeal process may resume later, pending the outcome of the disciplinary process.
- 11.31 An appellant may appoint a representative - for example a Students' Union Adviser. This representative may not be a solicitor or other legal practitioner.
- 11.32 Appellants will not be disadvantaged because of bringing an academic appeal.

Grounds for an Appeal

- 11.33 A PGR candidate has the right to appeal decisions made on:
- a assessment of the research proposal;
 - b upgrade of registration;
 - c annual review
 - d examination of the thesis.
 - e discontinuation due to lack of academic progress
- 11.34 A PGR candidate may appeal against the outcome of assessment for any taught module delivered as a constituent element of a Professional Doctorate programme by using the procedure in Section 9 of the [Academic Regulations](#).

11.35 Any appeal must be based on either or both of the following grounds:

- a that performance was adversely affected by illness or other factors which the PGR candidate was unable, or for valid reasons unwilling, to divulge before the decision was made. The PGR candidate's request must be supported by medical certificates or other documentary evidence acceptable to the Appeals Panel, indicating clearly why such evidence was not previously presented;
- b that there has been a material administrative error, or that the assessment(s) was not conducted in accordance with the Research Degrees Regulations, or that some procedural irregularity has occurred.

11.36 PGR Candidates may not appeal on any ground which:

- a has already been considered and rejected unless additional evidence in support of the appeal is provided and there is a valid reason (supported by evidence) why the additional evidence was not submitted originally;
- b claims that academic performance was adversely affected by ill health, where there is no medical evidence certified by a recognised medical practitioner or hospital consultant or other evidence deemed appropriate to support the application;
- c disputes only the academic judgement concerning the PGR candidate's performance in any academic work.

11.37 Given the existence of procedures for complaint and grievance, alleged inadequacy of supervisory or other arrangements during the period of study shall not constitute grounds for an appeal.

Submitting an Appeal

11.38 PGR candidates wishing to exercise a right of appeal must give notice in writing, using the [appropriate proforma available on My.ARU](#), to the Academic Registrar within 20 working days of the date of the written notification of the decision leading to the appeal.

11.39 International PGR candidates for whom a discontinuation decision has been made and who are studying under a Student Route Visa should submit their academic appeal within 10 working days of the date of the letter notifying them of the decision to avoid the withdrawal of the sponsorship of their Student Route Visa (in line with UKVI requirements).

- 11.40 Only in very exceptional circumstances and with the explicit agreement of the Chair of the Senate, acting on the advice of the Academic Registrar and/or the International Office, is an appeal outside the normal time limits considered.
- 11.41 A PGR candidate wishing to appeal on grounds of illness is required to send to the Academic Registrar supporting documented medical evidence, explaining the reasons why the evidence was not originally presented.
- 11.42 A PGR candidate wishing to appeal on the grounds that there has been a material administrative error or that the assessments were not conducted in accordance with the Research Degrees Regulations is required to send to the Academic Registrar such documentary evidence as is appropriate to support the appeal. Such evidence must be sent to the Academic Registrar at the same time as the proforma is completed. The Academic Registrar will notify the Doctoral School, the appropriate Faculty's Director of PGR candidates and their First Supervisor that an appeal has been submitted.
- 11.43 The Academic Registrar has the right to call for additional written evidence from the PGR candidate and/or ARU staff and to include any such additional evidence as s/he thinks is conducive to a better-informed judgement.
- 11.44 Once an appeal has been lodged with the Academic Registrar, the appellant may continue and fully engage with his/her course, without prejudice to the outcome of the appeal, provided that in doing so the appellant does not put him/herself or others at risk. The final decision regarding attendance ARU or in a placement remains with the Faculty Director of PGR candidates who may take action in accordance with the Fitness to Practise Regulations within the Rules, Regulations and Procedures for Students.

Initial scrutiny

- 11.45 The Academic Registrar acknowledges receipt of the formal notice of appeal. Two staff, from a pool of the Academic Registrar, Deputy Academic Registrar, Examinations and Academic Appeals Manager and the Quality Assurance Manager undertake an initial scrutiny of the appeal upon receipt by the Academic Registry within 15 working days of receipt of notice of the appeal. The Academic Registrar dismisses the appeal without further action where:
- a the criteria for grounds for an academic appeal are not satisfied;
 - b there is either no evidence provided to support the appeal, or that such evidence is clearly not timely.

- 11.46 All other appeals which satisfy the grounds for an academic appeal and for which timely and appropriate evidence has been provided are progressed to the informal resolution stage at Faculty level.
- 11.47 The Academic Registrar provides written notification to an appellant of the outcome of a dismissed appeal. This notification includes an explanation for why the appeal has been dismissed and confirms which staff undertook the initial scrutiny. The notification also informs the appellant that he/she can request a review of the decision to dismiss the appeal. Such requests are made by the appellant in writing to the Academic Registrar within ten working days of the date of the notification of the outcome.
- 11.48 On receipt of a request for a review of the decision to dismiss, the Academic Registrar appoints a Director of PGR candidates from a Faculty which is not associated with the appellant and their supervisory team to review the original decision within 10 working days of the request being made.
- 11.49 If the outcome of the review supports the initial decision, the Academic Registrar dismisses the appeal in writing within 10 working days of the review being concluded.
- 11.50 If the outcome of the review does not support the initial decision, the appeal progresses to the Informal resolution stage at Faculty level.

Investigating an Appeal (Stage 1)

- 11.51 All academic appeals which, following initial scrutiny by the Academic Registrar or review by a Director of Research Candidates from another Faculty, satisfy the grounds for an academic appeal are forwarded to the Deputy Dean (Research & Innovation) in the relevant Faculty for his/her consideration for investigation. If the Deputy Dean agrees that there are grounds for an appeal, the Academic Registrar upholds the appeal and notifies the appellant of the decision within ten working days.
- 11.52 If the Deputy Dean contests the appeal, they initiate an internal resolution process within the Faculty. Under the internal resolution process the Deputy Dean meets the appellant to discuss the appeal and seeks to resolve the matter at a local level. An internal resolution meeting is conducted in the most appropriate medium for the appellant. The appellant may be accompanied at the meeting by a friend or Students' Union Adviser. This meeting must take place within 15 working days after referral from the initial scrutiny stage. A written record of the discussion is kept by the Deputy Dean and the outcome of the meeting is reported by the Deputy Dean to the Academic Registrar, clearly stating whether the appeal is upheld or dismissed.

- 11.53 If the appellant fails to attend the meeting, and does not provide a valid reason for non-attendance, the Deputy Dean is not required to re-arrange the meeting but proceeds to consider the appeal. The Deputy Dean is permitted to dismiss the appeal on the grounds that the appellant has not engaged with the internal resolution process.
- 11.54 If, following the conclusion of the internal resolution process, the appeal is no longer contested by the Deputy Dean, the Academic Registrar upholds the appeal and notifies the appellant within ten working days. In such cases, and where appropriate, the Chair of the PGRCPSC arranges for the PGRCPSC to review its decision in the light of additional information provided through the appeals process within 15 working days of the letter upholding the appeal.
- 11.55 Where, following the conclusion of the internal resolution process, the appeal remains contested by the Deputy Dean, the Academic Registrar dismisses the appeal and notifies the appellant of the decision (including an explanation for why the appeal has been dismissed) within ten working days.
- 11.56 Where the Deputy Dean recommends upholding the appeal, the Academic Registrar submits the recommendation to the PGRCPSC for consideration. The normal expectation is that the PGRCPSC accepts the Deputy Dean's recommendation. If the PGRCPSC is not prepared to accept the recommendation, a formal written statement, with the reasons for not doing so, is submitted to the Academic Registrar by the Chair of the committee.
- 11.57 If, following the dismissal of the appeal at Stage 1, the appellant is dissatisfied with the outcome they may request that it is referred to a Stage 2 Appeals Panel Hearing if:
- a the appellant has engaged with the internal resolution process AND
 - b additional substantive evidence, which has not been presented previously, is subsequently submitted by the appellant. The additional evidence must be related to the grounds and reasons cited in the original submission of the appeal. The submission of additional evidence at this stage of the process cannot be used as an opportunity to change the grounds of the appeal (e.g.: citing alternative material administrative error).
- 11.58 An appellant wishing to exercise the right to request a Stage 2 Appeals Panel Hearing is required to notify the Academic Registrar, in writing, and supply the required additional evidence, within 15 working days of the date of the communication confirming the Stage 1 outcome. No arrangements are made to conduct a hearing until the additional evidence is submitted. If no further evidence has been received by this deadline, the request for a hearing, and therefore the academic appeal, is dismissed.

Appeals Panel Stage (Stage 2)

11.59 The membership of the Appeals Panel comprises:

- a two academic staff members of the RIC or RDC, one of whom acts as Chair. None may be members of PGRCPSC, the Faculty in which the appellant is registered nor have been associated with the appellant or their supervisory team in any way;
- b a postgraduate research candidate, nominated by the President of the Students' Union, who may not come from the same Faculty as the appellant.

11.60 The Examinations and Academic Appeals Manager in the Academic Registry acts as Executive Secretary to the Appeals Panel but is not a Panel member. In addition, a Report Secretary shall be appointed by the Academic Registry. The Dean or Assistant Director of the Doctoral School is also present to provide guidance on the Research Degrees Regulations and /or processes, but shall not act as Appeals Panel members.

11.61 The following have the right to be present and to speak at sittings of the Appeals Panel:

- a the Director of Research Candidates from the appellant's Faculty
- b the President of the Students' Union (or an elected representative of the Students' Union);
- c the appellant and his/her friend or a representative of the Students' Union.

11.62 Neither ARU nor the appellant is legally represented during the conduct of a hearing of the Appeals Panel.

11.63 Exceptionally, in the event of the unavoidable absence of a Panel member (e.g. due to illness), in order to reduce the inconvenience to the appellant, the Panel Hearing may proceed with three members provided that the appellant has no objections to proceeding with a three member Panel.

Procedure

11.64 The Academic Registrar convenes an Appeals Panel within no more than 20 working days following receipt of the notification from the appellant (see Regulation 11.58 above). Prior to the Appeals Panel meeting, the Report Secretary:

- a ascertains from the appellant whether s/he objects to the attendance of the President of the Students' Union at the Appeals Panel;
- b gives notice to the appropriate Director of Research Candidates and the President of the Students' Union of the date, time and place of the meeting;
- c gives notice in writing to the appellant by way of personal delivery or if this is not possible by recorded postal delivery to the appellant's last known address, such notice stating:
- d the nature of the appeal;
- e the date, time and place of the hearing of the Appeals' Panel and its membership;
- f that the appellant has a right to be heard at the hearing accompanied, if the appellant so wishes by a friend;
- g that in the appellant's unavoidable absence, the appellant may be represented by a proxy (who may be a member of the Students' Union) nominated ahead of the hearing by the appellant;
- h that the appellant has a right to submit a written statement or written evidence for consideration by the Appeals Panel and that evidence may be presented by the Secretary;
- i that the appellant is responsible for informing witnesses in support of the case of the details of the hearing of the Appeals Panel and for securing their attendance at the hearing;
- j that the appellant is responsible for informing the Report Secretary of the Appeals Panel as soon as possible of the names of witnesses being called and whether the appellant wishes to be accompanied by a friend (and if so the name of the friend).
- k provides members of the Appeals Panel, the appellant, the Director of Research Students and the President of the Students' Union (or elected representative) with copies of all relevant documentation.

Conduct of a Formal Hearing

11.65 ARU reserves the right to involve such other individuals as it thinks appropriate to the presentation of the case.

11.66 Minutes are taken of all hearings. The minutes are kept by the Academic Registry.

- 11.67 The hearing is conducted in the following sequence:
- a the appellant or friend in support of the case. The evidence may be in writing and/or witnesses may be called;
 - b witnesses in support of the appellant;
 - c the Faculty Director of Research Candidates with a view to demonstrating that the appeal should not be upheld. The evidence may be in writing and/or witnesses may be called;
 - d witnesses in support of the Director of Research Candidates;
 - e final statement by the appellant or friend or representative of the Students' Union;
 - f final statement by the Director of Research Candidates.
- 11.68 The Director of Research Candidates and witnesses, the appellant and his/her friend have the right to be present during the taking of evidence. All have the right to put questions to the witnesses and to each other, except that none has the right to put questions on the other's final statements.
- 11.69 If the appellant does not appear at the hearing, the Appeals Panel may proceed to deal with the appeal in the appellant's absence provided the Panel is satisfied that the Secretary has properly notified the appellant of the hearing.
- 11.70 The Report Secretary informs the appellant of the recommendation of the Panel within 10 working days.

Appeals Panel Decisions

- 11.71 The Appeals Panel sits in private and having heard the appeal decides:
- a whether the appeal can be upheld;
 - b if so, the recommendation to make;
 - c if not, to dismiss the appeal.

Outcomes Available to the Panel

11.72 The Appeals Panel, having heard the appeal, may, if satisfied:

- a For cases involving material administrative error or irregularity refer the matter to the PGRCPSC with an instruction to reconsider its decision in the light of the findings of the Appeals Panel. The normal expectation is that the committee upholds the Appeal Panel's decision and acts accordingly. If the committee is not prepared to reconsider its original decision, a formal written statement with its reasons for not doing so, must be submitted to the Academic Registrar by the Chair of the Committee.
- b For cases involving Illness or Other Factors if it is satisfied that the appellant's performance in the assessment was adversely affected by illness or other factors which s/he was unable or unwilling for valid reason to divulge before the assessment, the Appeals Panel will refer the matter to the PGRCPSC with an instruction to reconsider its decision. The normal expectation is that the committee will act accordingly. If the committee is not prepared to reconsider its original decision, a formal written statement of its reasons for not doing so must be submitted to the Academic Registrar by the Chair of the Committee.
- c For cases involving a recommendation by examiners at the viva-voce stage if the Appeals Panel decides that a PGR candidate has valid grounds for an appeal then one of the following recommendations is made to the next meeting of the PGRCPSC: i) that the candidate be given the opportunity to be examined as a first attempt. This may be with or without a viva voce examination; ii) that the candidate be given the opportunity to resubmit. This may be with or without a viva voce examination.
- d Where there are no Grounds or Grounds of Insufficient Weight dismiss the appeal, if it is satisfied that the appellant has failed to establish the grounds for the appeal.

11.73 The normal expectation is that the PGRCPSC acts accordingly. If the PGRCPSC is not prepared to reconsider its original decision, a formal written statement with the reasons for not doing so, must be submitted to the Academic Registrar by the Chair of the Committee.

11.74 The Report Secretary notifies the appellant of the Panel's recommendation within 10 working days. The Report Secretary forwards the report of the Panel to the PGRCPSC for consideration. The appellant is, at the earliest possible opportunity, notified by the Report Secretary of the PGRCPSC's decision. A report of the Panel hearing is submitted to the RDC for information.

Office of the Independent Adjudicator

- 11.75 If a student is not satisfied with the outcome of the appeals or academic misconduct process, the student may make representation to the Office of the Independent Adjudicator for Higher Education (OIA). For these purposes, the final communication to the appellant also serves as the 'Completion of Procedures Letter' required under OIA procedures.

Complaints

- 11.76 ARU has a formal Student Complaints Procedure which is published in the [Rules, Regulations and Procedures for Students](#), and an [admissions complaints procedure](#).